

Topic 5.4 - Responding: growth rather than endurance

A real classroom situation

Two teachers leave the same staff meeting, at which the head has announced that nothing can be done about class sizes this year.

Mr Bilal goes back to a Class 6 of sixty-two and continues exactly as before, more tired each term. When a trainee asks him about group work he says there is no point with these numbers. He is not wrong about the numbers.

Miss Ayesha goes back to a Class 6 of sixty-two and changes one thing: she stops trying to mark every exercise in every notebook and instead marks one question thoroughly for every pupil, in rotation, and uses the time saved to prepare the first ten minutes of each lesson properly. Her class is still sixty-two. Her Tuesdays are different.

Neither of them changed the class size. Only one of them changed anything.

Explanation

Separating what is within a teacher's control from what is not

The figure above divides a teacher's situation into three regions, and the division is the whole content of this topic.

What you control. Your preparation, your first ten minutes, how you speak to a pupil who is wrong, what you read, whose advice you seek, how you mark, what you do with the time you have. This region is smaller than a trainee hopes and much larger than a demoralised teacher believes.

What you can influence. A colleague's practice, a departmental habit, a head's decision, the way a routine works in your part of the school. You do not command these, and you are not powerless over them either. Unit 3's change-agent role operates here, and so does its warning that influence requires standing earned by doing the ordinary work well.

What you do not control. Pay scales, class size, the examination system, the electricity supply, the district's paperwork, the newspaper column. These are real, they are the source of most of the difficulty in this unit, and no amount of individual effort moves them.

The practical claim is simple and uncomfortable: **most professional frustration comes from spending effort in the third region.** Mr Bilal's conclusion about class size is accurate, and it is being used to justify inaction in the first region, where he does have room. That substitution is so common it is worth naming as the characteristic failure of an experienced teacher in a hard system.

A caution, so this is not misread. Naming the third region as outside your control is not the same as saying it is acceptable, and this topic is not an argument that teachers should quietly absorb whatever conditions they are given. Class sizes of sixty-two are an institutional failure. Teachers collectively, through associations and professional bodies as Unit 1 described, are exactly who should be pressing on that. What the distinction says is narrower: while it is unresolved, you still have Tuesday, and what you do with Tuesday is yours.

This is where the misconception about resilience belongs. *The answer to difficult conditions is resilience.* Resilience is a real quality, named in Unit 3 among the seven, and offered as the whole answer it becomes a way of relocating a system's failure into an individual's character. A teacher who burns out under sixty-two pupils and no support has not failed at resilience. The useful question is not how much you can endure but what, within the first two regions, would actually reduce the load.

Growth and development as a response rather than endurance

Endurance and growth look similar from outside for about a year, and then they diverge sharply.

Skaalvik and Skaalvik's (2020) study of 262 Norwegian high-school teachers is useful here for its structure rather than its numbers. They measured demands against **resources**, and the resources were autonomy and supervisory support. What that framing supplies is the practical point of this whole unit: when you cannot reduce a demand, the other lever is a resource. Growth is what deliberately adding resources looks like over a career.

The resources actually available to a teacher in a Pakistani government school are smaller than the ones in that study and are not nothing:

- **A colleague who will talk honestly about teaching.** The single most valuable and most neglected resource in any school. It costs nothing and requires only that you ask.
- **A method that reduces work.** Miss Ayesha's rotation is one. Marking less thoroughly but more usefully is not a compromise; it is often better assessment, as Unit 4's material on evidence argued.
- **Knowing something well.** The preparation burden falls sharply once you genuinely understand the content, which is why subject study is a workload intervention and not only a quality one.
- **A small, real improvement that worked.** Unit 3's researcher role produces these, and their second value is psychological: a teacher who has changed one thing and seen it work holds a different belief about the next thing.

The figure above is the method, and three stations deserve emphasis.

Name the challenge precisely. "My class is impossible" cannot be acted on. "Eleven of my sixty-two cannot read the textbook" can.

Place it honestly. Most challenges have a part in each region. Class size is outside; what happens in the first ten minutes with a class that size is inside.

Decide in advance what would show it worked. Unit 3's researcher discipline, and the station most often skipped. Without it you will conclude whatever you hoped.

The unit ends here deliberately. Four topics have described conditions that are genuinely hard and, in several respects, not your fault. That description is only

worth having if it ends in something you can do on Monday, and the honest list of what you can do is short, real, and enough to build a career on.

Activity: Place it, then change it

Work individually for ten minutes, then in pairs.

Write down three challenges you expect to face, or already face, in a Pakistani classroom. Be specific: not "lack of resources" but the particular thing that is missing and what it stops you doing.

For each, place it in the three regions and mark which parts fall where. Then choose the one with the largest share inside your control and take it through the flowchart to a single change and a piece of evidence you would collect.

In pairs, attack each other's plans on one question: **could you actually do this next week without anyone's permission?** If not, the change is too large; make it smaller.

Allow 30 minutes.

Check your understanding

1. Name the three regions and give two examples of a teacher's situation in each. (*Remember*)
2. Explain why most professional frustration comes from effort spent outside all three. (*Understand*)
3. Mr Bilal is right about class size. Explain precisely where his reasoning fails. (*Apply*)
4. Explain why offering resilience as the answer to structural conditions relocates a system's failure onto an individual. (*Analyze*)
5. Give three resources available to a teacher in a poorly resourced school, and say what each one reduces. (*Apply*)
6. Why is deciding the evidence in advance the station most often skipped, and what goes wrong when it is? (*Analyze*)

Summary

A teacher's situation divides into what they control, what they can influence, and what they do not control. The first is smaller than a trainee hopes and larger than a demoralised teacher believes; the second is where the change-agent role operates and requires standing; the third contains most of the conditions described in this unit. Most professional frustration comes from effort spent in the third region, and the characteristic failure of an experienced teacher in a hard system is to use an accurate judgement about the third region to justify inaction in the first.

Naming something as outside your control is not saying it is acceptable. Structural conditions require structural remedies and collective action; the distinction is about what remains available while they are unresolved.

Because burnout comes from the balance of demands and resources, adding a resource is a lever when removing a demand is not. The resources genuinely available include an honest colleague, a method that reduces work, knowing the content well, and one small improvement that demonstrably worked. The method is to name the challenge precisely, place it honestly, choose the smallest change that touches it, decide the evidence in advance, act, and check.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can place a challenge accurately in the three regions.
- ☐ I can explain why an accurate complaint about conditions can still be an excuse.
- ☐ I can answer the claim that resilience is the response to structural difficulty.
- ☐ I can name resources available to me that cost nothing.
- ☐ I can turn a named challenge into one change small enough to make without permission.

Try this at your practicum school

Do the method once, in full, on something real.

Name a challenge you have actually met on placement. Place it. Choose the smallest change inside your control. Decide in advance what evidence would show whether it worked. Make the change for one week. Check.

Write half a page, and include the honest answer to one question: was the change too small to matter, or did it matter more than you expected? Both answers are useful findings. Trainees consistently underestimate how much a change in the first ten minutes of a lesson can alter the rest of it.

Summative task

Write 450 to 500 words.

Mr Bilal and Miss Ayesha left the same meeting with the same class size.

Analyse the difference between their responses, then take one challenge from Topic 5.1, place it in the three regions, and design a response. Your answer must state what you are *not* claiming to fix, defend your change against the charge that it is too small to matter, and address the objection that asking teachers to adapt to bad conditions lets the system off the hook.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Use of the regions (Apply)	Places a real challenge accurately, including the parts that fall outside control
Honesty about limits	States plainly what the proposed change does not fix
Defence of a small change (Evaluate)	Argues why a small change within reach beats a large one that requires permission, without pretending it solves the structural problem

Criterion	What a strong response does
Answering the systemic objection (Analyze)	Engages seriously with the charge that individual adaptation excuses institutional failure, rather than dismissing it

Further reading

- Skaalvik, E. M., & Skaalvik, S. (2020). Teacher burnout: Relations between dimensions of burnout, perceived school context, job satisfaction and motivation for teaching. A longitudinal study. *Teachers and Teaching*, 26(7-8), 602-616. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13540602.2021.1913404> Cited here for its demands-and-resources structure; the study is of 262 Norwegian high-school teachers.
- Hargreaves, A. (2000). Four ages of professionalism and professional learning. *Teachers and Teaching*, 6(2), 151-182. <https://doi.org/10.1080/713698714>

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